

MONTH CYCLE TABLE

Rulebook

A 4-player draw-discard card game · 60-card custom deck

Months 1–12 · Five Colors · Gear-Based Scoring

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1 • Overview

Month Cycle Table is a **4-player draw-discard card game** built around a 60-card custom deck. The core loop is simple: draw, check for a win, discard, let opponents react — then repeat.

Core Flow

- Each player normally holds **5** total cards.
- On your turn, draw to **6**.
- If those 6 cards form a legal winning pattern, you may **win (tsumo)**.
- Otherwise discard back to 5; other players may **claim** that discard.
- Scoring uses exactly one 6-card winning pattern.

Key Concepts

Month	A number from 1 to 12 assigned to each card.
Color	One of five colors: G (Green), R (Red), Y (Yellow), K (Black), B (Blue).
Code	Player-facing reference using two letters: AA, AB, AC ...
Gear	The count of open (visible) cards in your open area. Required for higher-point patterns.
Open Area	Face-up locked cards from chi / pon / kan claims.
Concealed Hand	Cards only you can see; only these may be discarded.

2 • Components

The deck contains **60 unique cards**, each identified by:

- A **display code**: two letters: a prefix (A–E) and a suffix (A–L), running from AA to EL.
- A **month**: 1 through 12.
- A **color**: G (Green), R (Red), Y (Yellow), K (Black), or B (Blue).

Total cards	60
Months per deck	1–12 (repeating every 12 cards)
Each month appears	Exactly 5 times
Colors per deck	G (Green), R (Red), Y (Yellow), K (Black), B (Blue)
Each color appears	Exactly 12 times

Card Code Sequence

Each card code is two letters: a **prefix** (A–E) and a **suffix** (A–L), giving 60 unique codes from AA to EL. Colors cycle through the five colors **two cards at a time**, then repeat. Here is how the first two prefix groups look:

Prefix A — cards AA through AL:

Codes	Color	Codes	Color
AA, AB	G · Green	AG, AH	K · Black
AC, AD	R · Red	AI, AJ	B · Blue
AE, AF	Y · Yellow	AK, AL	G · Green (cycle repeats)

Prefix B — cards BA through BL (color cycle shifts by one step):

Codes	Color	Codes	Color
BA, BB	R · Red	BG, BH	B · Blue
BC, BD	Y · Yellow	BI, BJ	G · Green
BE, BF	K · Black	BK, BL	R · Red (cycle repeats)

This pattern continues through prefixes C to E. Each new prefix group starts the color cycle one position later, so every color appears exactly 12 times across the full deck.

3 • Players, Seats & Dealer

The game uses exactly **4 players**: East, South, West, North.

Starting points	15 each
Initial dealer	Chosen randomly; becomes East
Dealer retention	East stays dealer if East wins the hand
Dealer pass	Otherwise passes to the next player

East bonus	None — East has no scoring advantage
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4 • Match Structure

- A match lasts up to **12 rounds** (numbered 1–12).
- After round 12, if one player leads, the match ends.
- If round 12 ends tied for first, play enters **sudden death** until the tie breaks.
- If any player falls to **0 or below**, the match ends immediately.

5 • Hand Setup

- Shuffle all 60 cards.
- Deal **5 cards** to each player.
- The remaining **40 cards** become the wall.
- East takes the first turn.

6 • Hand Structure

Each player has a **concealed hand** and an **open area**. The winning hand check uses *all* cards — concealed + open.

- Only concealed cards may be discarded.
- Open cards are face-up and locked for the rest of the hand.
- Before drawing or claiming: normally 5 total cards.
- After drawing or claiming: temporarily 6 total cards.

7 • Turn Flow

On your turn:

Draw 1 card from the wall.

You now have 6 total cards.

If the 6-card hand is a legal winning pattern, you may declare tsumo.

If you do not win, discard 1 concealed card.

Other players may respond to that discard.

If no claim succeeds, the next player takes a turn.

A player may pass a legal tsumo and keep playing.

8 • Claims

After a discard, claims are resolved in **priority order**. A higher-priority claim blocks lower ones.

Priority	Claim	Brief Description
1 (highest)	Ron	Win on the discard — beats everything.
2	Kan	You hold all 4 other cards of that month.
3	Pon	You hold 3 other cards of that month.
4 (lowest)	Chi	Next player only; takes discard into open area.

8.1 • Ron

If adding the discarded card to your hand creates a legal 6-card winning pattern, you may **ron**. Multiple players may ron the same discard; each is paid separately by the discarder.

8.2 • Chi

Only the next player in turn order may chi. No sequence is required — chi simply takes the discarded card into your open area. After chi, discard one concealed card. Chi opens exactly 1 visible card.

8.3 • Pon

You may pon only if you already hold **exactly 3 cards of the same month** as the discard (across concealed + open). All same-month cards plus the discard become open, creating a 4-card open month block. After pon, discard one concealed card.

8.4 • Kan

You may kan only if you already hold **exactly 4 cards of the same month** as the discard. All become open, creating a 5-card open month block. After kan, discard one concealed card.

8.5 • Self Kan

On your own turn, if your concealed hand contains **all 5 cards of the same month**, you may open them immediately without needing an opponent discard. After self kan, discard one concealed card.

9 • Winning

- **Tsumo**: win on your own draw.
- **Ron**: win on another player's discard.
- A winning hand is always exactly **6 total cards**.

If a 6-card hand matches more than one pattern: remove patterns that fail the gear rule, then use the **highest-point** result from the remaining valid patterns.

10 • Gear Rule

Gear is the literal count of visible open cards in your open area. Each point tier has its own open-card floor.

Pattern Tier	Minimum Open Cards	Example Source
3 pt	3	Three chi claims
6 pt	2	Two chi claims
9 pt	1	One chi claim
12 pt	None	No gear requirement
15 pt	None	No gear requirement

11 • Round Bonus

Each round N targets **month N**. If your winning 6-card hand contains month N, you gain **+3 points** (once per win).

- Applies to both tsumo and ron.
- Can raise a 15 pt hand to 18 pt.
- Sudden death rounds have no target month.

12 • Settlement

12.1 • Tsumo

Winner gains full value; each of the 3 opponents pays one-third.

3 pt tsumo	Each opponent pays 1
6 pt tsumo	Each opponent pays 2
9 pt tsumo	Each opponent pays 3
12 pt tsumo	Each opponent pays 4
15 pt tsumo	Each opponent pays 5
18 pt tsumo	Each opponent pays 6

All legal totals are divisible by 3 — settlement is always clean.

12.2 • Ron

The discarder pays the full value; the winner gains the full value.

12.3 • Multiple Ron

Each ron winner scores separately. The discarder pays each winner in full.

13 • Winning Patterns

All patterns use exactly **6 cards**. If multiple patterns apply, the highest valid (gear-eligible) score is used.

13.1 • 3-Point Patterns

Pattern	Requirement	Gear
One Color	All 6 cards share one color	≥ 3 open
Odd or Even, Five Colors	All 6 cards odd or all even · all 5 colors present · all 6 months different	≥ 3 open
Consecutive Months	Six different months in order	≥ 3 open

13.2 • 6-Point Patterns

Pattern	Requirement	Gear
Three Month Pairs	3 pairs from 3 consecutive months	≥ 2 open
Three Month Pairs, Two Colors	3 pairs from 3 different months · at most 2 colors	≥ 2 open
Three Month Pairs, Odd/Even	3 pairs from 3 different months · all odd or all even	≥ 2 open

13.3 • 9-Point Patterns

Pattern	Requirement	Gear
Two Month Threes	3 cards of one month + 3 cards of a consecutive month	≥ 1 open
Two Month Threes, 3 Colors	3 + 3 of two months · at most 3 colors total	≥ 1 open
Two Month Threes, Odd/Even	3 + 3 of two months · all odd or all even	≥ 1 open

13.4 • 12-Point Patterns

Pattern	Requirement	Gear
Five With Side Month	5 of one month + 1 neighboring month · all 5 colors present	None
Four With Double Side Month	4 of one month + 2 matching from the prev or next month · all 5 colors	None
Four With Split Side Months	4 of one month + 1 previous + 1 next month · all 5 colors present	None

13.5 • 15-Point Patterns

Pattern	Requirement	Gear
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Straight Run	6 adjacent card codes in full deck order (e.g. AA AB AC AD AE AF)	None
Consecutive Months, 1 Color	Six different months in order · all one color	None
Alternating Months, 1 Color	6 cards of one color across alternating months in deck order	None

Odd/even is determined by deck order: AA is odd, AB is even, AC is odd, and so on. Straight Run means 6 codes that are consecutive in the full deck sequence. Alternating Months means the color lane skips months in an alternating step pattern.

14 · End of Hand

A hand ends when:

- A player wins by **tsumo**.
- One or more players win by **ron**.
- The **wall is exhausted** — hand is a draw, no one scores, dealer rotates normally.

15 · End of Match

The match ends when:

- A player falls to **0 or below**.
- Round 12 ends and one player is alone in first place.
- Sudden death ends with one player alone in first place.

If round 12 ends tied for first, play continues in sudden death rounds until the tie breaks. Sudden death rounds have no round bonus target month.

16 · Practical Notes

- Card codes (AA, AB, AC...) are the player-facing references used throughout play.
- Some 15-point patterns depend on deck order — read patterns through the visible card codes.
- Month labels are numeric: 1 to 12.
- Color labels: G, R, Y, K, B.
- Open-card count (gear) is critical — a strong hand is invalid if it misses the open-card floor for its point tier.

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